



“Two-thirds of the entire economy is impulse buying,” Paco Underhill claimed in his book, *Why We Buy: The Science of Shopping*. Underhill’s book was a groundbreaking tome of consumer behavior in 1999, but recent research concurs with his observation. In January of 2010, Market Force (a provider of customer intelligence solutions) conducted a survey of 6,000 consumers to collect data on spending habits and store loyalty, focusing on retail grocery stores and consumer packaged goods.

Market Force was interested in possible patterns of behavior that prompted consumers to try a new product. They focused on six different categories: Cereals, Coffee and Tea, Cleaning Products, Health and Beauty, Snacks, and Beverages. Across all categories, seeing something on the shelf or on an endcap display was responsible for the most trial purchases. Promotions and coupons drove the most new sales for cereals. Within every category, however, retailers could count on one thing: the impulse buy. Even with a grocery list in hand, about a third of respondents would add to their cart a new product that looked interesting, 40 percent would add an